

READING AND VARIOUS RESOURCES

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5.1 INTRODUCTION

Learning to read is one of the most important basis of education. It is the basis of being able to read and learn in life. Further, it is essential that teachers should have a robust understanding of what reading is and the best pedagogical practices that should be taken up in the classroom to build lifelong readers. The purpose of learning any language is to be able to communicate, express oneself creatively, and use language to explore further arenas. This chapter aims to build an understanding of reading, explore classroom practices and strategies for teaching and learning, reading, and foster classroom environments that support the development of reading skills.



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**5.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- Appreciates and understands that reading is essentially a meaningful process;
- Observes the developmental aspect of reading in the early years;
- Identifies the sub-processes that constitute the process of reading;
- Creates meaningful and purposeful opportunities for children to read;
- Plans to create an environment conducive to nurturing reading in the primary grade classrooms;
- Identifies print resources to facilitate reading in meaningful ways.

5.3 WHAT IS READING?

Reading is the ability to be able to understand a text i.e. comprehend the meaning or the message that the text holds. The purpose and goal of reading is comprehension. It is a process by which one can make meaning or understand what is written. Reading involves multiple dimensions; however, primarily, it can be observed that reading occurs when one is able to engage with the meaning of the text.

For a student, the ability to derive meaning from texts is extremely vital because it will either enable or hinder their progress in all school subjects. A student may get the concept of addition, but will need the ability to read the question to solve it. For effective reading, i.e., for effective comprehension, students need to engage with the text and make meaning out of it. Reading has a functional purpose to it, as text carries meaning. It has the purpose of conveying a certain message. For example, an illiterate person may not read the names of medicines but can still recognise them by looking at the back of the tablets. The print image helps them tell apart their cough medicine from their knee pain medicine.

Similarly, during pretend play, Gaurav scribbles or writes a “grocery list,” saying “milk, bread, bananas,” demonstrating understanding that print is used to remember things. Gaurav has understood the **functional aspect of literacy**.

Nidhi goes to the bank sometimes with her grandfather. Her grandfather tells her that he used to work in this bank, whose name is Canara Bank, and shows



her the blue board with Canara Bank written on it. One day, she was going with her mother and she saw a Canara Bank board on the way. She immediately said, 'Nanu's bank'.

The above examples show that readers do not just necessarily rely on the knowledge of letters and script to engage with print. The above examples show the importance of context in reading. It is a crucial aspect for children learning to read. It helps them to build a hypothesis about the print that print is meaningful, and the context helps them build the meaning. It is important to understand that **context is crucial in comprehending the text.**

Suniti reads the sentence "The big tiger ran up the mountain." She read the sentence fluently, but when asked, "Where did the tiger go??", she could not reply. This shows that:

- The learner is decoding (breaking a word into parts/letters and then joining them to read) the words.
- The learner did not build an understanding of the sentence, as the focus was on breaking down words to read.
- The focus is on sounding out words, not on grasping meaning.

Soham is reading the above given sentence as, "t tiger, h hat, e for egg, b of ball, I ice cream, g goat, t tiger, i ice cream, g goat, e egg, r rat...."

What is Soham doing? To read a word, he identifies the letters of the English alphabet with the associated objects that were rote memorised. He is just identifying letters of the word, not the word. Subsequently, this will result in a time-consuming and tiring process. How will he engage with the meaning of the word when he cannot even join the letters to form a word? Is he really reading?

Let us take another example from the classroom. Ananya is reading aloud a familiar storybook, but there is no coordination between where her finger is on the text and the word she is saying. When the teacher stopped her and asked her to point to a particular word, the learner could not identify the word. This shows that the learner had memorised the text and was pretending to read. Such examples highlight the **gap between recognition, decoding skills, and comprehension**, which is crucial for developing lifelong readers. Reading is understanding. **If comprehension is not taking place, it is not reading but merely decoding.**

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Learners coming from literacy-rich environments also have an understanding of the functional aspect of reading and writing. The responsibility of the school is to build on what learners already know. But the traditional teaching practices that are commonly followed in schools do the reverse. First, learners have to learn the alphabet, be able to do the letter-sound correspondence correctly, and then start reading two-letter and three-letter words. This takes up 2-3 years of school. The learner is expected to deal with the mechanics of reading patiently till they can make any meaning out of it. The learner has to go through a tedious process of rote memorising the mechanics of a language before she can make any meaning out of it. By the time the learners reach the stage of meaning making, they find the process tedious, boring, and have lost interest in it.

Leaving behind the meaning-making part, learners are made to start with the mechanical aspect of language learning, i.e, starting with letters and moving to decoding. There is no meaning-making happening. This is so unlike the oral language they learnt at home, where every word the child learnt was on purpose, as the child wanted to convey something. There was a purpose and meaning attached to it, and it came naturally. That's the organic way we all learn a language. It is not mechanical, meaningless, or boring. We pick up words, sentence structures as we observe and listen to adults around us speaking.

What children are learning is decoding. However, what they enjoy is stories, communication, and engagement. They are looking for communication, expressions, and connections, which is the purpose of learning a language. That is how the pedagogy of reading and writing should be. The following pointers describe what happens when the focus is entirely on the alphabet to teach reading, while overlooking the importance of meaning-making:

1. Reading becomes mechanical, not meaningful

- If learners are only taught to decode letters and sounds, they may be able to “read aloud” words but not actually understand them.
- This reduces reading to a mechanical skill instead of making sense of language.

2. Missed the purpose of reading

- The real goal of reading is comprehension. When the focus is only on alphabets, learners may not see reading as a way to communicate, enjoy stories, or connect with their experiences.



3. Loss of motivation and interest

- Children often find stories, rhymes, and meaningful texts engaging. If reading instruction is limited to drills on letters and sounds, they may lose interest because it feels repetitive and disconnected from their lives.

4. Limited vocabulary and context development

- Exposure only to alphabets or isolated words does not help children. We need to build vocabulary, world knowledge or an understanding of how language works in context.

5. Struggle with higher-level reading skills

- Skills like prediction, inference, and critical thinking grow when children read for meaning. Overemphasis on alphabets delays these essential abilities.

5.3.1 Reading is Comprehension

Kindly read the following text:

jedzenie dzisiaj smakuje okropnie

Are you able to read it?

What some of you were able to do was to decode it on the basis of your knowledge of letters. But could you engage with the text? Could you share its meaning?

The process of reading includes many aspects that involve meaning making, knowledge of language, letter-sound recognition, prediction, etc. Reading is essentially a meaning-making process that involves many other sub-processes. Being able to recognise all the letters is not reading. It is decoding. Reading involves comprehension, as every text carries a meaning with it. If one is unable to take away the meaning from the text, one has not read it. We might have observed students who are able to join letters and read paragraphs fluently, but are unable to tell the meaning. They look blank when they are asked to share the meaning of what they have read. It is because they have been able to decode or read without meaning. The purpose of reading is not just fluency or recognition of words. The primary purpose of reading is meaning. Reading is a meaningful process. Anything which is causing it to be meaningless is a hindrance to the true nature of reading.

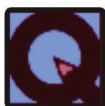
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Reading is not truly happening if the reader is not able to understand the message of the text. Reading is more than the mechanical act of recognising words. Reading involves constructing meaning from text based on the reader's own knowledge and experiences and the information given in the text. Without comprehension, reading becomes a superficial activity, where words are pronounced but ideas are not grasped.

So let us try to summarise what reading is.

- Reading is a meaning-making process. It involves the construction of meaning from the written text.
- Reading is not just the recognition of letters or the mere sounding out of words and sentences. Reading involves understanding the meaning of the text, relating it to one's own experience, and developing a perspective on the information given in the text.
- Comprehension and reading are integral and inseparable.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 5.1**

Identify the sentences as True or False.

1. Reading is a meaning-making process.
2. It is not important to derive meaning from text.
3. Reading is all about fluency.
4. The purpose of reading is for understanding.
5. When the reader is not able to understand the meaning, it is not reading.

Answers: 1. True 2. False 3. False 4. True 5. True

5.3.2 Need to Learn Reading

Why did we all learn to read? Or rather, why is reading considered so important? If we look at the education system, reading is the most basic and essential component, as our competency in reading will help or hinder our ability to transact other subject areas. This is because the medium of receiving knowledge of any subject is a language. Therefore, if one is not able to master the language, it hampers the process of gaining knowledge in other subject areas. For example, if a student is struggling with understanding a language that is also the medium



of instruction for other subject areas, how will that student gain knowledge in science or social studies, or computers? This will impact the overall learning of the student and impact their life and study skills considerably.

The ability to read is also important in daily life. It helps us stay connected to the world by reading books, newspapers, magazines, etc. It is important in the documentation of various financial and legal matters and matters of daily living, like reading directions on the road, names of things on packets, shops, bills, etc. Nowadays, to use smartphones, one requires, basic understanding or skills of reading.

5.3.3 Skills Involved in Reading

Reading is a complex and purposeful process that extends far beyond the mechanical act of recognising letters and words. At its core, reading is a **meaning-making activity**, where the reader actively interacts with the text to construct understanding. It is not a passive reception of information, but a dynamic process that requires the integration of visual cues, linguistic knowledge, and prior experiences.

Readers constantly predict, infer, and cross-check information with their background knowledge, making reading a highly cognitive activity. Thus, reading involves the simultaneous use of **grapho-phonics cues** (letter–sound relationships), **syntactic cues** (sentence structure), and **semantic cues** (meaning from context).

Reading is a complex cognitive process that involves several interrelated skills. These skills work together to help a person understand, interpret, and engage with written text. Reading is an intricate process that involves many skills and aspects, like:

- Familiarity with the language
- Familiarity with the context
- Knowledge of script
- Knowledge of sentence structure

Reading is not simply decoding letters and sounds. It is a process that involves the integration of multiple aspects to construct meaning from text.

1. Grapho-phonics Cues (Visual/Phonics)

- Grapho-phonics refers to the way written letters are sounded or spoken. Grapho-phonics cues are the hints that readers get from the

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letters (grapho = writing/letters) and **sounds** (phonic = phonemes/sounds) of words. They help a reader match the printed word with how it sounds.

- Grapho-phonics is used to describe the relationship between the way words look and the way they sound. It allows the readers to use their knowledge of letter patterns and sounds to identify words, along with other cues such as pictures, context, etc.
- Example: “*I like to eat rice, jaggery, and ghee.*” The learner reads “*I like to eat rice,*” and then pauses at the next word. The learner, based on experience might think it should be *dal*, but recognises that letter ‘d’ is not there, so cancels it out. At the same time, starts thinking of things with ‘j’ like *jam*, but also realises *jam* is a small word, but the word written there is bigger. Also, *jam* is not a combination with rice. So while reading the word he can see the next word as *ghee* also. So, all these cues help the learner in reading the word *jaggery*. The learner uses the visual cue of the length of the word, the letters of the word, the context given in the sentence of food combination, and previous knowledge to be able to read the word. The learner uses **grapho-phonics cues using the visual length of the word and the number of letters to guide reading**, not just sound-letter mapping.
- Example: When a learner sees an image of a bat and knows that it is a bat, although may not be able to recognise letters, the learner will call it a bat and not a hat, as the learner understands the difference between the two things.
- Engagement with the text helps learners learn that the letter combination “th” represents the sound /th/ as in “tooth” and /d/ in “them. They use this knowledge and experience to read other words.
- If a learner reads a very short word incorrectly (e.g., says *flew* when the word is *flying*), they can self-correct: “That word is too long to be ‘flew’ — *I need to look again.*” Grapho-phonics cues help in making meaning and self-monitoring while reading.
- **Grapho-phonics cues help children by giving an instant visual clue about the type of word, how it might sound, and whether their decoding attempt makes sense.** It guides attention, supports accuracy, and builds confidence in handling both short sight words



and longer unfamiliar words.

2. Syntactic Cues (Grammar/Structure)

- The reader uses knowledge of sentence structure, grammar, and word order to make predictions.
- Helps readers anticipate what kind of word is likely to come next.
- Example:
 - i. In “The elephant is _____,” a noun or verb may be expected depending on context.
 - ii. “_____ is eating a mango.”, a noun or adverb is expected depending on the context.

3. Semantic Cues (Meaning)

- Semantic cues are meaning-based clues readers use to make sense of a text.
- Readers use the meaning of the word, prior knowledge, or the context given in the sentence,
- Helps make educated guesses about unfamiliar words or phrases.
- Example: Understanding that “The girl threw the _____ in anger” would have something that is handy and can be thrown.
“The lady was speaking to the _____” likely ends with a human being.

4. Pragmatic Cues (Context and Purpose)

Pragmatics is the study of the rules associated with the use of language in conversation and broader social situations. Pragmatics cues can be non-linguistic, like eye contact, turn-taking, or linguistic as in conversations.

- Pragmatic cues help readers understand the social and cultural context of the situation in the text. For example, a child is reading a book and comes across an unfamiliar word, “soared”. The child looks at the given illustration of a bird flying and guesses the meaning of the word as flying high and not as walking or sleeping, etc.
- Pragmatic cues help readers understand the purpose of writing the text and the audience for whom it was written, and the situation in it. Example: A letter will be written to someone specific; a poem could

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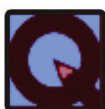
have a specific or general audience with a specific theme; a newspaper article will be for a widespread audience. It can also include contexts which are unfamiliar, like a student may find it difficult to understand an article about ice hockey if one is unfamiliar with it, or about the manufacturing of wooden flooring, or about the rituals of a festival which they have not heard of.

Let us take a look at another example:

“The Fed raised interest rates again this quarter.”

A reader with a knowledge of financial or economic context knows this affects borrowing costs, inflation, etc. However, someone without a context of the investment market may find it difficult to understand this.

Reading is not a linear process. Rather, it includes the integration of various language cueing systems, grapho-phonics, syntax, semantics, and the skill of making predictions. Skilled readers use all of these cueing systems simultaneously and interactively to construct meaning, rather than relying primarily on decoding or phonics alone.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 5.2**

1. What are Semantic cues?
2. Give 2 examples of Grapho-phonetic cues.
3. What do you understand by Syntactic cues?
4. Can you think of a situation when you were unable to understand the meaning of a text because of unfamiliarity with the context?

5.4 SCHEMA THEORY OF READING

What is a schema? A schema is a mental structure that organises knowledge. It is a mental framework or organised body of knowledge built from past experiences. The human mind has schemas for everything-from objects to feelings to actions. For example: a schema for a ball for a child might include things like toy, rolling, play, joy, colourful, etc. This schema will help the mind interpret any new ball that might be similar or different from the ball they already have.

A schema for an adult for a bus might include the following aspects: bus stop,



seat, many people, strangers, tickets, journey, etc.

Let us take another example: You walk into a restaurant you have never been to before. You know restaurants have menus, waiters, and a process of ordering food. You expect to be seated, handed a menu, order food, wait, eat, and pay at the end. You understand phrases like “Would you like the bill?”. This is a schema for a restaurant. Another person might have a different schema for a restaurant based on his/her experience.

The **Schema Theory of Reading** explains how readers use their **prior knowledge (schemas)** to understand, interpret, and remember new text. Every reader has a certain set of experiences, understanding, and knowledge. When the reader reads a new text, the reader tries to make meaning of the text based on what the reader already knows. When we read, we don’t process each word in isolation — we connect the text to what we already know.

The richer and more relevant our schemas, the easier it is to make sense of new information.

Schema theory is relevant for reading because it highlights that comprehension is a process of integrating new information with existing schemas. Comprehension occurs when a reader connects the text with prior knowledge. Schema theory suggests:

- Reading is not just decoding text—it is comprehending new text using what one already knows. For example, if the reader has prior knowledge about a market, the reader will better understand the book on markets.
- Comprehension occurs when a reader connects the text with prior knowledge. For example, understanding a story about city life is easier if you know something about cities, or a text on evaporation will be easier to comprehend if you have some data on it.
- The more relevant schemas a reader can activate, the better they understand the text. For example, a reader has to know about the dish ‘khichdi’ to enjoy the folktale ‘khichdi’.
- Schemas can change and grow with new experiences and information. Schemas can be modified. For example, if a reader has a certain schema about magic, it might change or grow with new information

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on magic.

- If a reader lacks the background knowledge or experiences to relate to the text, understanding is harder.

How can teachers use this in the classroom?

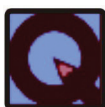
Activate prior knowledge before reading. For example, Before starting with the story “The monkeys and the cap seller’ from Mridang, class 1 textbook, the teacher can ask:

Do you know what a cap is? Have you seen a cap seller?

What do monkeys eat?

This activates schemas about what students already know about caps, monkeys.

During reading, the teacher can show pictures from the story, and explain the meanings of words like fists, basket, scratched, etc. This will help to build a new schema based on the story setting, understanding of the text. The teacher can ask questions to students in between to predict “what will happen next?” This will help bridge gaps and build connections between what is already known to new schemas. Students make predictions and inferences based on their schemas, or help students adjust their schema to fit new information.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 5.3**

Choose a story from the Grade 2 textbook and share the kind of questions you will ask to connect the text with prior knowledge and help in building new schemas.

5.5 READING VARIETY OF TEXTS

As readers engage in a variety of texts and read for various purposes like leisure, for study, for information, etc. Whenever we pick up a text to read, we have a purpose for reading it. A reader would engage in a story differently than compared reading a science lesson. The former reading would be more informal and could involve emotional engagement or the formation of an opinion at some level. Later on reading would be more factual and informative. So, it can be said that different texts demand different types of reading. The texts can be broadly seen in two categories:



5.5.1 Narrative Texts

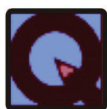
Narrative texts include novels, stories, poems, biographies, personal narratives, etc. In schools, teachers should deal with narrative texts in a way that students engage with them by relating experiences, feelings, opinions, etc. Students should be able to respond to the text by understanding the characters, setting, plot, conflict, its solution etc.

5.5.2 Expository Texts

Expository texts are texts that are usually found in science textbooks, news articles, research articles, encyclopaedias, etc. These are informational texts, and the purpose is to inform, explain, describe or give factual information. The reader would read these texts with the aim of gaining information about something and using it.

Teachers should be careful that both types of texts are dealt differently in the classroom. If in a narrative text, the purpose is to provide answers to the questions given after the story, the reader will read it for the purpose of information in it rather than engaging with the emotion in the text. This will not let students appreciate the literary aspects of the narrative and will be a big hindrance in developing good readers or creating an interest for reading.

Sometimes, a text can be both narrative and expository in nature i.e. a story can have informational content also. A teacher has to ensure that justice is done to the text and it is handled appropriately. Further, students are able to differentiate between the structure and purposes of two types of texts. Examples are “The story of Amrita” from class 4 EVS textbook, “Every Drop Counts”, “When the Earth Shook” from class 5 EVS textbook.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 5.4

1. Given below are the names of lessons, topics from NCERT textbooks. Write whether you think these are Narrative or Expository texts.
 - o The monkey and the Cap seller – Class 1, English Textbook
 - o Nasruddin’s Aim, Class 4, English Textbook
 - o Why? Class 4, English Textbook
 - o Mountains- The pride of India, Class 4 SST textbook
 - o When the earth shook, class 5 EVS textbook



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- Pick up any one of the above chapters and share a lesson plan.

5.6 READING STRATEGIES USED BY LEARNERS

Early readers use various strategies to read. These strategies are based on their schemas and the reading strategies used in the classroom or at home.

5.6.1 Using Picture Clues

Learners look at illustrations to guess what's happening in the text. This helps them build a context and comprehension. The learner may see an illustration in the book and just name the characters or objects they may see, like *boy*, *mumma*, *cycle*, *park*, etc.

As learners get more vocabulary and experience in reading, they start forming sentences using clues from the illustrations and the written text.

5.6.2 Predicting

Predicting means making intelligent and informed guesses. Learners make predictions about what will happen next based on the story. Prediction is an excellent strategy to build engagement with the text and actively think about the text. For example: after hearing "It started to rain," they might predict that the children started enjoying the rain.

5.6.3 Using Repetition and Patterns

Children enjoy using repetitions and patterns as these make the text more predictable and enjoyable. For example: the song 'Fruits for all' from class 1 *Mridang*:

"Five yellow mangoes hanging on the tree,/ One for the traveller who rests under the tree./ One for the bird who nests on the tree./ One for the squirrel who runs up the tree./ One for the rabbit who lives under the tree./ One for you to share with me. /Five red apples hanging on the tree,/ One for the traveller who rests under the tree./ One for the bird who nests on the tree./ One for the squirrel who runs up the tree./ One less for the rabbit who lives under the tree./ One for you to share with me." (p. 86)

5.6.4 Self-Monitoring

Learners notice when something does not sound right or make sense, then they reread it. In this way, they combine meaning (semantic), grammar (syntactic),



and social/context (pragmatic) clues. This supports comprehension, accuracy, and meaning. For example, the child reads “*The monkey is flying*” but sees a picture of the monkey jumping, so rereads and fixes it to “*The monkey is jumping.*” When the reader is self-monitoring, the reader is using Semantic, Syntactic, and Pragmatic cues together.

5.6.5 Inferencing

Inferencing involves using clues from the text along with reader’s own background knowledge to figure out information that the author has not stated directly in the text. When an early reader makes an inference, they are noticing clues in the words, pictures, or layout of the text, linking clues with what they already know (their schema) and drawing a conclusion that is not explicitly stated. It is essentially the bridge between what is said and what is meant.

Early readers can use facial expressions or gestures in illustrations to figure out emotions, notice cause and effect relationships:

Example 1: “She dropped the flower vase. Now there are shards on the floor” which implies the vase broke.

Example 2: “Vishal” put on his woolen cap and gloves before leaving the house” which implies it must be cold outside.

5.6.6 Skimming

Skimming is used by older and experienced readers to get the general idea or main points of a text quickly. It is mostly used for informational texts to see what the text is about, rather than for small details like reading headings, subheadings, and bold words. For example: skimming a news article to see if it’s about a sports match or an incident, skimming a chapter in a science textbook.

5.6.7 Scanning

Scanning is also used by older and experienced readers to find a specific piece of information in a text rather than reading the entire text. It helps in looking for facts or any specific data. Scanning involves moving your eyes quickly over the text, looking for keywords, numbers, or names, and ignoring everything else that doesn’t match your search. For example: scanning a science chapter to find the definition of “Gravity”, scanning a timetable to find a flight for Kozhikode, looking up a word in a dictionary, finding an answer to a question in a passage, etc.

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Thus, we see that all these strategies help the readers build strong comprehension skills. Reading for comprehension is the essence of literacy. It enables readers to engage with ideas, form interpretations, and apply knowledge in real-life contexts. Instruction that integrates reading and comprehension helps students become thoughtful, independent, and lifelong readers.

5.7 TYPES OF READING

Every reader reads for a different purpose or in a different method. It also depends on the choice of text being read. Below, you will be able to read about different types of reading that a reader may engage in.

5.7.1 Intensive Reading

As the name suggests, the purpose of intensive reading is to engage and read the text carefully to get some information, understand details or facts for a particular purpose one may have. It is careful and focused reading to understand details. It can be done to understand a concept or a topic, like in a textbook, or any other book or text that is informative.

5.7.2 Extensive Reading

Extensive reading is generally reading for pleasure. It usually involves texts like stories, novels, and narrative texts. The purpose is on overall understanding and not on grasping any specific details from the text. One can read at one's own pace and analyse or reflect on the text. For example, a child reads a storybook like *Panchatantra* or *Phirkee Bachchon Ki* for fun.

5.7.3. Loud Reading

Learners usually read loudly when they start to read. Loud reading implies learners verbalising the text while reading. Reading aloud helps them listen to themselves as they read. As children hear themselves, they can often detect mistakes or when something does not make sense. They learn to pause, re-read, and self-correct. As learners gain confidence in their own reading, they gradually shift towards silent reading.

5.7.4. Silent Reading

Silent reading is when a person reads text without speaking aloud—using their eyes and mind to understand the content. Silent reading helps readers develop independent reading skills, improve comprehension, and build a lifelong reading habit. It allows the reader to engage with the text at their own pace



and in personal reflection. Teachers can help students choose appropriate books and provide support during reading, like word meanings and look for signs if students are decoding or are unable to comprehend. After reading, teachers can ask questions to encourage comprehension, reflection, and do some reader-response activities.

5.7.5 Shared Reading

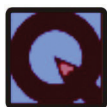
Shared reading is an approach in which two people usually read a text together. It could be a teacher and student, or two students. It could be that both students read together, or one reads while the other listens, and then the second child reads the next part while the first child listens. Then they share their understanding. This is beneficial when students are developing good reading skills and are able to read with comprehension. It is often used in early literacy classrooms, but is beneficial at all levels. Teachers should ensure that both readers have a copy of the text and help them choose appropriate books according to their interests.

5.7.6 Guided Reading

Guided reading is an approach where the teacher works closely with a single student or a small group of students who are at a similar reading level. The purpose of this reading approach is to help students develop effective reading strategies by working in smaller groups. The teacher can ask comprehension questions to ensure students are reading with meaning.

5.7.7 Independent Reading

Students read independently, and the teacher's role is minimal. Students choose their own texts and read them at their own pace. Students can maintain their own reading logs and fill out their response activity sheets. This is appropriate for learners who have a good command of reading and comprehension.



CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING 5.5

1. What is the difference between shared and guided reading?
2. What do you think would be the best method for an early grade classroom?
3. What challenges can a teacher face when a student is reading independently?

**Notes****5.8 INSTRUCTIONAL STRATEGIES FOR READING**

As they start school, they also have to start learning a second language. We will be using English as a second language here. Although the strategies could apply to any second language. We have to understand that the purpose of learning any language is communication and creative expression. Therefore, our strategies to teach and learn should be aligned to this purpose.

Traditional approaches to teaching second languages are based on rote memorising the alphabet of the language and then starting from reading two-letter words, three-letter words, and increasing complexity. Meaning-making and the purpose are lost in this process. The learner gets entangled in learning the rules of the language, vocabulary, and translation. It is tedious and tiring. Amidst all this, the priority is given to reading and writing and not speaking, creativity, and expression. So, the learner is not left with much to be engaged in.

Instead, what should be done is to focus on the meaning-making aspect of language. Language learning is not rote memorisation of grammar rules, but a way to make sense of the world. The basis of second language learning should be the same as that of the first language i.e., use of children's literature and using and creating experiences as part of the language classroom. Although in a second language, the teacher will need to build on the first language learnt. Teachers will need to create an environment in the classroom where learners can immerse themselves in the language and learn from it. The strategies can be summarised as:

- It has to be learner-centered and experiential. Language should not be taught in isolation but through real-life contexts and themes.
- Using local stories, culture, and examples to make English or any other second language relatable.
- Use of children's literature.
- Meaning prioritised over accuracy.
- Teachers can use the child's mother tongue or the first language of the school to explain difficult concepts and support understanding.
- Activities should involve negotiation of meaning.

Let us look at some pre-reading and post-reading strategies that will help us understand an ESL/ any other language classroom better.



5.8.1 Pre-Reading strategies

Before starting to read a book, the teacher should make the learners familiar with the theme of the story by either discussing it or by showing pictures or introducing the characters of the story, etc. Initially, the learners can use their first language to share and discuss. Pre-reading activities are important as they help learners familiarise themselves with the theme, predict the content of the story and to build curiosity and interest in the text.

1. Show pictures from the book

Show illustrations or photos from the book or text and discuss them before reading. A teacher can ask questions like “What do you see in this picture?”, “What is happening in the picture?”, “What do you think the story could be about?”. These questions help learners build an understanding and predict the content of the story.

2. Prediction Activities

Teachers can hold the cover page of the book and share the title of the story and ask, “What do you think the story could be about?”, “Who might be the main character?” etc. These questions build anticipation, engage imagination and help learners build an understanding and predict the content of the story.

5.8.2 Post-reading Strategies

Post-reading strategies help strengthen comprehension and recall. It gives opportunities to connect with the theme of the text and express themselves creatively. Post-reading activities should also be response-based i.e., activities done after reading that focus on the learner’s personal, emotional, or creative response to the text rather than just factual recall.

1. Retelling the Story:

The teacher can ask students to retell the story in their own words. The teacher may use cues like “What happened first?”, “Then what happened?”, “How did it end?”. Or the teacher may write the lines from the story in a jumbled form on different sheets of paper, and students may be asked to rearrange them in the correct sequence. This can be a small group activity. The teacher may ask students to write or share how the text made them feel, what they liked/disliked, or what they related to. For example: after reading *Thank God*, I felt that the farmer could, or retelling the story from another character's perspective.

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2. Draw and Label:

Teacher can ask students to draw a scene from the story, their favourite character, or a new ending. Students can also label the picture or write a sentence about it.

3. Story Mapping:

Story mapping means organising the sequence of the story in a visual format. The teacher can divide the story into sections for the task. Students can be divided into small groups, and each group can be given one section to draw and illustrate, and then put all illustrations in a sequence. A teacher can also cut out pictures from the story and mix them up, and ask students to reorder them correctly. This helps with understanding the structure of the story and improves recall.

4. Role Play/Skit:

Students act out the story or part of it. The teacher can divide the class into smaller groups for this task. The teacher can assign characters to students and help them with writing and deciding dialogues. The teacher can help students practice the skit, and then students can present their skit in the class.

5. Critical Thinking:

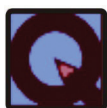
To help learners connect and engage with the story, the teacher can ask questions like “Has this ever happened to you?”, “How would you feel if...?”, “What would you do in this situation?”. The teacher can ask students to give a new title or a new ending to the story. This helps to encourage critical thinking and problem solving, and the use of language creatively.

6. Letter to a Character of the story:

Teachers can ask students to write a letter to a character, giving advice, asking questions, or expressing feelings. For example: “Dear Ravi, I think you are doing a wonderful job with ...”

7. Word Web:

The teacher can help build ideas, connections, and vocabulary with the main theme of the story and ask students to suggest related words. This helps learners to build vocabulary and explore more ideas related to the given theme. For example, after completing the story “The Little Fir Tree” from the grade 3 NCERT textbook, the teacher can pick the word ‘magic’ and brainstorm on it with students. This can also be used as a pre-reading activity.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 5.6**

Choose a story from the Grade 2 English Textbook and plan pre- and post-reading activities around it.

5.9 RESOURCES FOR READING

This section elaborates on the various resources of reading that teachers can use in their classrooms.

5.9.1 Children's Literature

Children's literature holds an extremely important place in supporting learners to become lifelong readers. Children want to experience and explore the world around them. Literature acts as a bridge between the known and the unknown, between reality and fantasy, between facts and fiction, and allows children to traverse the roads beyond the ones known to them. It exposes its readers to the world of possibilities, removing them from their own narrow confines and challenging them to spread their wings. It allows them to think, feel, wonder, and dream. Stories have a magical effect on children.

For long, researchers and educationists have emphasised the need for and use of children's literature in classrooms. Literature influences children's language development primarily by providing meaningful content, around which purposeful reading, writing, and speaking activities can be built. To make the initial teaching of reading meaningful, teachers should begin with books and not flash cards, charts or other aids with names of objects, alphabets or their sounds/charts or other such aids. So it is important to build a literacy-rich environment around children, which includes print richness as well as meaningful transactions of print, which connect reading, writing, and speaking in meaningful and purposeful ways.

Therefore, it is important to provide children with a print literacy-rich environment so that they are surrounded by meaningful texts. Each classroom should have a class library or/ reading corner, and children are given ample opportunities to children to explore, interact, and read books. In the foundational stages, if the teacher can engage in more read-aloud, guided, and model reading sessions, it will cater to the learner's desire to read. The learner would engage in browse and read through books, and teachers spend quality time reading

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aloud books to them, children start to learn and display their understanding of literacy by engaging in various literacy activities such as talking about the story, looking at the text, pretend reading being read-out, story sequence and relating to the story at their own personal level and building a response to it and picture reading by looking at illustrations in the book.

Keeping this understanding of reading in mind and the limited exposure learners have of the English language, it is imperative that learners should be provided with immersive print-rich environments in the school and classroom so as to increase children's transaction with the functional aspect of print, where their attention is consciously drawn to the print available in the classroom. This will support and strengthen their understanding of the meaning-making process of reading.

5.9.2 Print Rich Environment

What is a print-rich environment? It should be a space that is inviting for the reader. It will definitely require putting up reading material, creating a reading corner, keeping stationery, doing reading-writing activities, etc. The purpose of creating a print-rich environment in a classroom is to make the classroom a collective space where the process of reading and writing can be transacted in a meaningful and authentic way. A print-rich classroom does not mean decorating or covering the walls from head to toe. It is about putting up print material that is interesting, relevant, and meaningful for the students. The reading material that is put up in a print-rich classroom should have a transactional purpose to it. For example, if a teacher writes a poem from the textbook on a chart, it has to be used meaningfully in the class. They can draw a weekly plan for that particular poem, which includes reading and recitation, listening to children's experiences around the theme of the poem, highlighting and writing the main words, building letter-sound connections, opportunities to draw and write, and playing some games around the poem. When the teacher reads and refers to this print material in the class, students also attempt to read it independently. In a print-rich classroom, a teacher will be constantly engaging with the reading material in the class and supporting students to do it as well through a lot of planned activities. A teacher can enrich the classroom with different forms of print, which can be used on a day-to-day basis in either the teaching-learning process or building or strengthening the classroom culture. It can include:

- Collection of books and children's literature of various genres.



- Dedicated space for reading and writing.
- Theme-based reading material, like stories, poems on charts.
- Informational material on charts like class rules, mid-day meal menu, student name chart, labels on things, student names, etc.
- Print/ chart written in the class as part of a language experience activity like a morning message, story, poem, recipe, steps to create something, etc.
- Display of children's work

5.9.3 Reading Corners/Collection of Children's Literature

Children's literature is the best way to initiate children's meaningful engagement with print. A good collection of children's literature, which is age-appropriate, contextual and interesting, indicates that the classroom culture values reading and it is an important aspect of the teaching-learning process. So, a reading corner is not just a corner but a dedicated space inside the classroom to keep children's literature for students to read.

- **Physical Space:** The space should be easily accessible by students and ideally, can be maintained by them. It can be created by keeping a rack in a corner, or tying ropes from one end to another and hanging books on it, or using a table and tying ropes around its legs to hang books. There should be enough space to display books so that students can easily access them.
- **Age-appropriate books:** Books should be according to the reading abilities of children. Picture books will be relevant for children who are starting to engage with books, one-liner books for children who are being introduced to literacy, two-liners and three-liners for children when they engage more with print. It is also important to note here that, as the text in books increases, so do characters and complexity of the plot. So, the teacher should assess how much children will be able to read and comprehend, and choose books accordingly. Similarly, children should be provided with context-relevant books so that children will be able to talk and engage with the theme of the book and have meaningful conversations around it as compared to a book that has a context or theme that is unfamiliar to children.
- **Variety:** A variety of books should be carefully selected, like picture books, story books, poetry collections, genres of children's literature, informational books, children's magazines, etc. A variety of literature will provide children

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with opportunities to engage with a variety of texts, characters, themes, and ideas. There should be enough books for all children in the class to read.

- Include materials for writing, like papers, pencils, and colours if children want to express themselves through writing or drawing.
- Teachers should think about a provision to change books from time to time so that students get new books to read. Teachers can exchange and circulate books in each other's classes from time to time, say weekly or fortnightly, so that children can get to read a range of books.

5.9.4 Children's Magazines and Posters

Magazines offer an interesting collection of a variety of reading material on a regular basis i.e, monthly or quarterly such as *Phirkee Bachchon Ki*, a bilingual magazine published by NCERT. NCERT has also published posters with picture stories, poems, and stories which can be put up in the classroom and are great for reading and discussion.

5.9.5 Material Created as Part of a Language Experience Activity

The language experience approach integrates speaking and listening, reading and writing through the development of a written text based on collective/ shared experiences of the children as a group. As children share their experience, the teacher facilitates the writing of the experience, focusing on written text and sentence structures. It includes shared experiences such as everyday happenings, common school or classroom activities or experiences, visits outside school, or personal experiences of students. When the teacher writes these texts in front of children, it strengthens the connections between written and spoken text. And since the created text stays on the classroom wall, children can revisit it multiple times and engage with the text and the experience of creating it. It can include varied experiences that children engage in, like games they play, a wedding in the village, the birth of a calf in a child's house, doing a science experiment in school, an experience of sitting in a metro train, etc. At times, children carry things dear to them to school, such as their loved toy, something they collected on the road, something they have saved from a long time, etc. These experiences can be validated in the classroom and given space as literacy activities, like a discussion about our most loved things, a morning message, etc. The teacher can write the words on a chart, which can be put up on the class wall for students to read and engage with. The reading material created as part of

a language experience activity strengthens print awareness and reading-writing connections. In this manner, print in the classroom becomes a functional part of the process of language learning as it is created and used in the classroom.

5.9.6 Display of Children's Work in the Classroom

A classroom filled with the work of children is a delight to be in and sends a message to students that their work and their learning are important. Furthermore, do not correct any errors in their work. Nobody wants errors to be displayed. The teacher can discuss with them about their writing and how they think they can add to it in their next writing. It is about engaging them with meaningful writing and strengthening their reading-writing connections. As their awareness and knowledge about reading-writing strengthen, they will grow into conventional forms of writing.

5.9.7 Jaadui Pitara

A 'wonder box' of play materials and learning-teaching resources to help teach English to learners at the foundational stage. It includes picture posters, poem charts, alphabet board and tracing cards.

5.9.8 Audio-Visual Material

Teachers can use Audio-visual materials, including videos, songs, and rhymes, which are effective in improving listening and speaking skills. Educational videos featuring animated characters, songs with catchy tunes, and rhymes with repetitive patterns engage young children and facilitate language acquisition.

5.9.9 Diksha Portal

Teachers can also use the DIKSHA portal to do more courses on understanding reading, writing, use of children's literature, print-rich environment, assessment, etc., for their own learning and growth. Teachers can also find resource material for students on this portal.

Reading is a meaning-making process, and it involves the reader, the text, and the culture or context around it. A print-rich classroom culture will have relevant material for children, a class culture that accepts their thoughts and experiences, and gives them space and freedom to express themselves. A teacher's role is to weave these experiences into opportunities for talking, listening, reading, and writing. However, if at the same time, the teacher maintains strict discipline

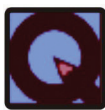


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in the classroom, gives no space to the thoughts and experiences of students, and directs and dictates all the interactions, this kind of a classroom will also look print-rich with all the nice materials, but it will be void of the culture and rationale of having a print-rich environment. It is not just about the physical space – it is about the culture of the classroom.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 5.7**

Plan the reading corner and print rich environment for your classroom. Share your ideas here.

**5.10 LET US SUM UP**

Reading is not merely recognising letters and words; it involves making meaning from the text. The reader should be able to engage with the text to make meaning. Moreover, readers should be provided with meaningful and authentic opportunities for learning to read. Reading in school should not be confined only to reading chapters of the textbooks. Readers should be provided with a variety of age-appropriate and interesting materials to read. The purpose of reading is to develop life-long learners with a passion for reading and enjoying literature and expressing themselves creatively.

Ultimately, the nature of reading is best understood as a blend of skill, strategy, and purpose. It is a skill because it requires systematic instruction and practice; a strategy because readers employ different approaches depending on their goals; and a purposeful act because every act of reading serves a specific function—whether to gain knowledge, follow directions, or experience the joy of literature.

In conclusion, reading is not merely recognising symbols but **constructing meaning** through active engagement with text. It is this dynamic and interactive nature that makes reading central to both learning and lifelong personal growth.

**5.11 END EXERCISES**

1. What do you understand by “Reading for meaning”?
2. According to your understanding, what would be the most effective strategy for teaching reading in an English language classroom at the primary level?

3. Explain the relevance of print-rich environment in the classroom? How will it support reading?
4. As a teacher, what challenges do you think, you will face in teaching English?

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